

Going for the Kill

The euphoria over the unilateral declaration of ceasefire by the most potent battalion of ULFA may be short-lived if the government and the pro-talk group fail to bring in more cadres to their fold

■ By Kaushik Deka in Guwahati

Anil Haloi (name changed), who had joined the United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) in 1988, was a disillusioned rebel till last month. He had been involved in kidnapping, murders, blasts and attacks on security forces, all in the name of struggle for independence. Instructions would come from the central leadership of ULFA, whom Haloi had never seen, and he would execute their subversive plans. But, his dream of an independent Assam still remains as distant as it was 20 years ago. Today, Haloi fears that some Bangladeshi would rule his motherland soon. "I have never met our Commander-in-Chief Paresh Barua, and Chairman Arabinda Rajkhowa. We want independence; but the state has become another Bangladesh. As Barua is sheltered by the Bangladeshi Government, he doesn't show any concern over the problem of Bangladeshi influx," says Haloi.

In fact, this influx is one of the main reasons which forced the Alpha and the Charlie companies of the 28th battalion of ULFA—its most potent strike forces—to declare a unilateral ceasefire on June 24. At a press conference held at Amarapur, a remote village in Sadiya sub-division of Tinsukia district, Mrinal Hazarika, the founder of the 28th battalion, said, "In this fight for independence, we have lost about 10,000 cadres, even as the ethnic population is being overwhelmed by the influx of people from Bangladesh, Nepal and elsewhere. If the current trend continues, the indigenous people of Assam would become a hopeless minority in their own ancestral land."

For the first time since its birth on April 7, 1979, ULFA has seen a rebellion from its own cadres. Though 13,000 militants, including many top ULFA leaders, have surrendered since 1991, the central leadership never faced

detractors within the banned outfit. Therefore, security analysts see the truce offered by the 28th battalion as a major success of the Assam Government in breaking the militant group. Sources close to the state home ministry told INDIA TODAY that Rajkhowa will soon join this offer. If that becomes a reality, Barua will be left with almost no command over the group. Euphoric over these developments, a belligerent Tarun Gogoi, chief minister of Assam, launched a scathing attack on the ULFA chief, saying that he must now free himself from the clutches of ISI. "The ULFA leaders till now have been serving the interests of the ISI," Gogoi said.

The backdoor negotiations for a ceasefire go back to the arrest of Hazarika in Siliguri in May 2006. On June 21 this year, he was released on bail, amid speculations that the Government was trying to use his services to engineer a split in the ULFA and bring a faction to enter into a truce. However, Hazarika insists that this truce should not be interpreted as a mutiny, but as an attempt to save the

unnecessary loss of blood. "We have been indisciplined, and are prepared to accept any punishment from our central leadership. But before that, our leaders should give due consideration to the issues we have raised," he says, adding that independence will be futile if they cannot secure the very existence of the natives of Assam.

Hazarika also reiterated that the ULFA central leadership would have to sit for formal talks. "We, battalion level leaders, are not competent enough to sit in such negotiations. We appeal to ULFA's central committee, the Centre and the Assam Government, to positively respond to the goodwill gestures of the battalion in finding a peaceful solution to the insurgency problem," he says.

Their appeal failed to impress their commander-in-chief who disbanded all the three companies and put the entire battalion under Bijoy Chisre. Barua also shot down any possibility of peace without a written undertaking from the

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SIPRA DAS

Government, specifying that the issue of sovereignty would be discussed during future talks. "I tried to convince him to come forward for talks. But he is adamant on the sovereignty issue," says noted litterateur Indira Goswami, who has been acting as a mediator between the rebel group and the Government. However, with growing isolation within the group, the ULFA head may soon find few supporters among his cadres. The leaders of the 28th battalion revealed that there was a rift within the outfit on the selection of the members of the People's Consultative Group (PCG), which was formed by the ULFA top brass to work out the modalities for their formal peace